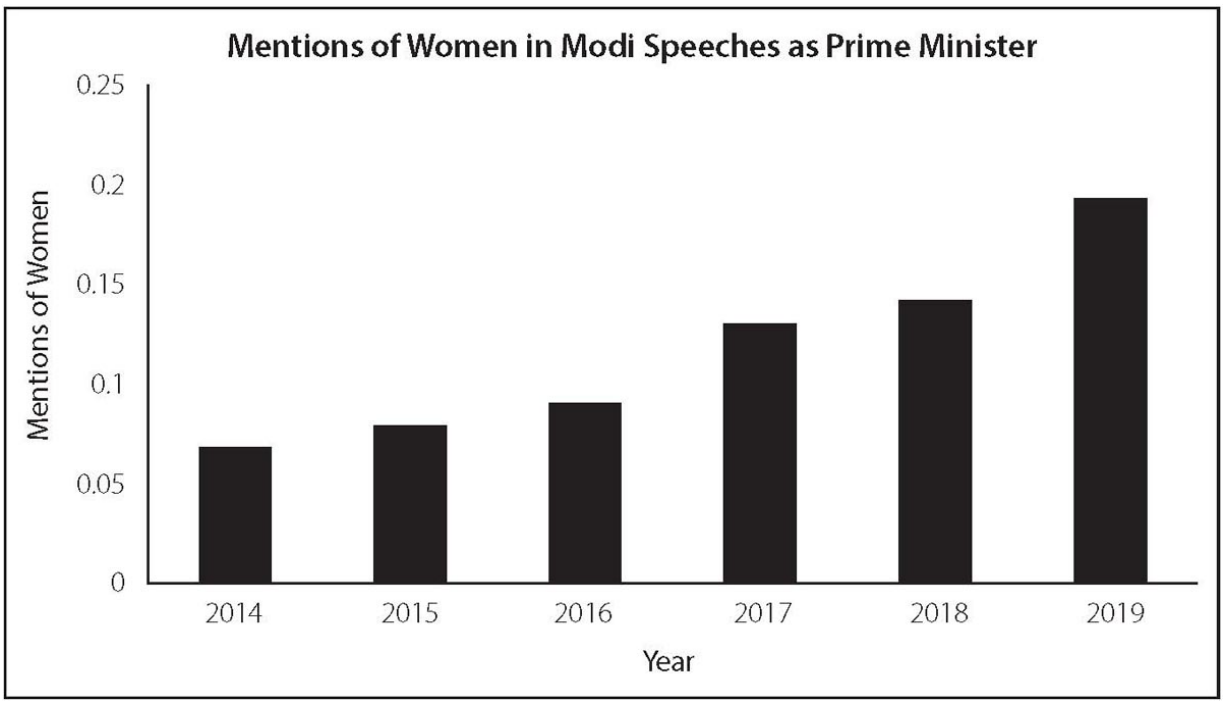


Source: Narad Index, Nalin Mehta and Rishabh Srivastava, for more details see Appendix 4/online on nalinmehta.in

Women cadre became a key BJP priority because the party saw female supporters as political galvanisers within households. Addressing a gathering of BJP Mahila Morcha workers in Karnataka in 2018, Modi spelt this out clearly. 'We will have to go house to house to expose Congress propaganda… I can say with experience that our Mahila Morcha workers are the most effective in this task,' he said. 'When women do this work, when they go house-house, sit down and talk, it has a double effect. First, when a woman convinces someone, she uses everyday domestic arguments, explains it in normal language. She does not do big lofty talk, she explains in simple terms and wins confidence like that. Being credible has a lot of power. You would have seen that when a woman gets convinced in a family, then the whole family gets convinced. We have always tried from the beginning that women have an equal share in every aspect of the social and economic spheres.'[63]

Modi has also been keenly aware of the symbolism of women leaders in power and often refers to this in his speeches. He told that same gathering that the country was now moving towards 'women-led development and not just development for women'. Arguing that